

State Agency Promising Practice

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Oregon: Using Funding to Improve Integrated Employment Services

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Project Background

The Impact of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agency Employment Contracting Methods and Service Payment Rates on Employment for Individuals with Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (IDD) is a project of the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston. The goal of this project is to explore how state IDD agencies' contracting and payment methods supported the use of innovative employment services, access to assistive technology, or improvements in the employment services workforce to ensure access to high-quality employment services. To explore this topic, we have selected eight states whose IDD agency and/or Medicaid Authority developed and implemented financing strategies that reflect the factors of interest.

Staff from the Oregon Office of Developmental Disabilities Services (DDS) provided information for this summary. Oregon focused on improving the state's information technology infrastructure and increasing access to information to enhance the quality and quantity of employment services available for people with IDD. While some initiatives began prior to 2020, others were the result of the state accessing American Rescue Plan Act (ARPA) funds.

State Initiatives

Improving the Information Technology Infrastructure

Impact Oregon, funded partly through state grants and matched with federal funds, represents the state's focus on building information technology resources to address

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the challenges community rehabilitation providers (CRPs) face in hiring employment specialists. Initially, the state considered addressing this challenge through the development of billboard advertisements. However, in consultation with partners in the community, including CRPs, Oregon determined that a better long-term strategy would be to build a website to inform the public about the type of work that employment specialists do. The website would also serve as a tool to support CRPs to access potential new staff members. DDS also created an Outreach and Marketing Toolkit to ensure consistency in how Impact Oregon is used.

Jobs Board

Impact Oregon includes a jobs board where CRPs can post open positions, descriptions of different types of careers that are available for working with individuals with IDD, success stories of people who began a new career pathway working with individuals with IDD, and a glossary of terms that are frequently used in the IDD field. The jobs board allows CRPs, case management organizations, and the state agencies that manage services for individuals with IDD to post jobs. The budget to implement and market the website was \$300,000 and is a blend of funds from the state general revenue budget with matching funds from the state workforce development agency. The state chose to use an external contractor to build and maintain the jobs board section of the website.



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One unique feature of the jobs board is that CRPs are required to post the wages or salary that will be paid for each job posted. Some CRPs have been reluctant to provide this information particularly if they offer a lower wage than other CRPs in the state. However, the state felt that this was important because most job seekers will not apply for a job unless they know the wage range for the position. Over time, CRPs have begun to see the value in this approach, and the state feels that trust in this requirement will improve over time as they hire applicants who found the job posting through the jobs board.

Employment Outcomes System

Another information technology infrastructure development that Oregon implemented was the Employment Outcomes System. DDS also administered and funded this initiative. CRPs that provide employment services and supports funded by DDS report data monthly on the number of people in individual supported employment, small group supported employment, and employment pathways services as well as the number of employment discovery profiles that have been created. CRPs also report on the average hours worked per week and the average wages earned per hour. The website also provides a listing of all active DDS employment service providers, which includes the CRP's name, website, phone number, and an email address for more information. Lastly, the public can use the website to compare CRPs in their community based on employment outcomes, and the services they have available.

Online Learning

Oregon also made use of ARPA funds. These initiatives are newer, so there is no information available on their impact. However, their development offers further evidence of Oregon's commitment to using information technology as a tool to improve employment services. Funding was made available for educational institutions to pilot the state's Introduction to Supported Employment curriculum; for a contractor to design, create, and build on an existing core competency online training module for employment professionals; and to convert an existing employment training curriculum designed for a classroom setting into an online learning format.

Technology to Deliver Services

DDS granted permission for CRPs to deliver services using multiple forms of technology, including employment services. However, the state found that many CRPs were hesitant to use technology in this way because they were unsure about how to use technology in the field, and they were not aware of resources like technology loan libraries that support the use of technology. In 2022, DDS offered \$10 million in ARPA funding to help case management entities and providers continue offering services and supports that will require Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) compliance after the end of COVID-19 pandemic.

Conclusion

The use of information technology and assistive technology are two strategies Oregon has used to build capacity and support service innovation for individuals who receive services from DDS. While at varying degrees of implementation, these initiatives are evidence that the state is working to modernize the delivery of employment services and supports to increase efficiencies in the system. Staff from DDS have indicated that Oregon plans to continue to use these types of strategies to increase access to and improve the quality of employment services.



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